Stablecoins need telcos, not telco apps.

Two specific plug-ins. Wholesale economics. No consumer crypto app required.

Telcos have been in payments for fifteen years.

The record is mixed, but the pattern is clear: the asset stack is the same in every market.

WHERE BANKS WERE WEAK

The telco became the financial system.

M-Pesa, MTN MoMo, Orange Money, Airtel Money, Tigo Money, JazzCash, EasyPaisa, bKash, GCash. The SIM became a practical financial identity; the telco payment arm became one of the largest financial businesses in the country.

M-PESA | MTN MOMO | ORANGE MONEY | JAZZCASH | BKASH | GCASH

WHERE BANKS WERE STRONGER

The telco built alongside the incumbents.

Wallets, authentication, digital banks. Axiata Boost in Malaysia. KDDI au PAY and au Jibun Bank in Japan. SK Telecom T Wallet and PASS. e&money and stc pay in the Gulf (stc pay → stc bank). Singtel + Grab → GXS Bank in Singapore.

BOOST | AU PAY | T WALLET | STC PAY | GXS BANK | E&MONEY

WHERE TELCOS STRUGGLED

Wrong vehicle, not wrong instinct.

Vodafone joined Libra/Diem in 2019 — directionally right on stablecoin rails, regulatorily impossible. Orange Bank tried head-on retail banking in France — directionally right on telco financial services, wrong market structure. Sold 2024.

Six assets telcos already have.

The common asset stack across every telco that ever made payments work — emerging or developed market.

01

Verified identity

Issued at SIM activation, often to a higher KYC standard than fresh on-ramp checks would meet.

02

Billing relationships

Tens to hundreds of millions of recurring postpaid and prepaid customers, paying every month.

03

Mobile money rails

Live e-money or wallet infrastructure already settling consumer transactions at country scale.

04

Retail cash networks

Hundreds of thousands of physical agents — the only practical cash-in / cash-out at street level.

05

Payment licences

E-money, payment institution, banking, money-services licences across dozens of jurisdictions.

06

Operating history

Years of regulator dialogue, AML programs, sanctions screening — credibility that can't be cloned.

WHAT THIS MEANS

"That is the part telcos got right."

These six assets were built for completely different reasons. They happen to be exactly what the global stablecoin platform layer now needs from the markets it cannot reach on its own.

The Stablecoin Orchestration layer is consolidating. Fast.

Two acquisitions tell you how the world's biggest payment networks responded to $15T of stablecoin volume.

2025 STABLECOIN VOLUME ON-CHAIN

$15 *trillion*

Roughly on par with Visa's annual volume.

2025

OCTOBER 2024

Stripe

acquires **Bridge**

DEAL VALUE **$1.1B**

Leading stablecoin payments orchestration company. Stripe gets the developer-facing rails for moving stablecoins as easily as fiat.

MARCH 2026

Mastercard

acquires **BVNK**

DEAL VALUE **$1.8B**

Largest enterprise stablecoin platform in Europe and the US. Mastercard gets the equivalent rails for its corporate base.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR TELCOS

The platform is set. The local layer is wide open.

The role on offer is the one telcos have always been good at: connectivity and identity, sold wholesale, into infrastructure that is finally large enough to matter.

A multi-step supply chain. Two steps belong to telcos.

Six steps the stablecoin economy runs on. The platform layer can do most of these in markets where it has presence. It cannot do them in most of the world. Two of the six steps fit telcos and only telcos.

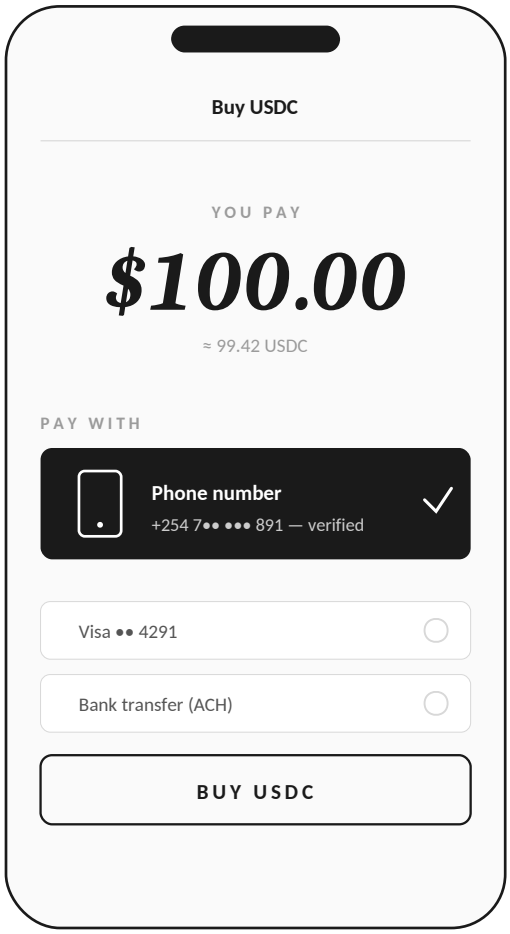
STEP	FUNCTION	WHO RUNS IT
01	***Issuance*** Mint and redeem the dollar.	Circle, Tether, Stripe, Mastercard issuers
02	***Custody*** Hold the keys safely.	Fireblocks, Anchorage, BitGo
03	***Liquidity*** Make markets in the asset.	Coinbase, Kraken, regional exchanges
04	***Compliance*** Screen and monitor flows.	Chainalysis, Elliptic
05	***Identity & on/off-ramp*** Verify the user. Move fiat in and out.	**PLUG-IN #1** ***TELCOS — phone-number rails***
06	***Cash interface*** Convert physical cash to digital value.	**PLUG-IN #2** ***TELCOS — wholesale agent network***

TWO PLUG-INS, ONE THESIS

Neither requires building a consumer app. Neither requires running a developer platform. Both sell raw materials telcos already operate at scale — into infrastructure other people are building.

Your phone number becomes the on-ramp.

One tap. The user never sees the telco. The telco never builds a consumer crypto app.



WHAT HAPPENS UNDERNEATH

01 *User enters phone number*

On-ramp recognises the carrier.

02 *Carrier returns identity attestation*

KYC already done at SIM activation, often to a higher standard.

03 *Fiat settles to the carrier*

Postpaid bill, prepaid balance, or mobile-money wallet.

04 *Stablecoin lands in user wallet*

Seconds later. One tap. No card scheme involved.

WHAT THE TELCO SELLS

One product solving two problems: payment + identity.

The on-ramp gets faster onboarding and lower compliance burden. The telco gets paid for the rail and the KYC.

Three layers, in increasing scale.

The phone-number plug-in is not a transaction-fee business. It is a stack.

01 SMALLEST

Transaction fees

A few percent of purchase value. The telco captures a slice as the payment-method provider.

02 LARGER

Float yield on operating capital

Customer e-money is regulator-protected. But adjacent corporate treasury and working capital — billions for major operators — earns materially more in stablecoin lending pools than in T-bills.

03 LARGEST

Credit originated against the phone number

Mobile-money operators already underwrite consumer lending at scale. Safaricom Fuliza disburses billions a year. Re-funding flows through stablecoin pools improves cost, speed and flexibility — and unlocks BNPL, salary advance, remittance-funded credit.

THE PUNCHLINE

For an operator with mobile-money at scale, this plug-in alone is plausibly larger than every previous telco Web3 initiative combined.

Stablecoin orchestration platforms cannot yet do retail cash.

Bridge, BVNK, Conduit settle to bank accounts. Most emerging-market users don't have one. The telco does.

M-PESA · ANNUAL VOLUME THROUGH AGENT NETWORK

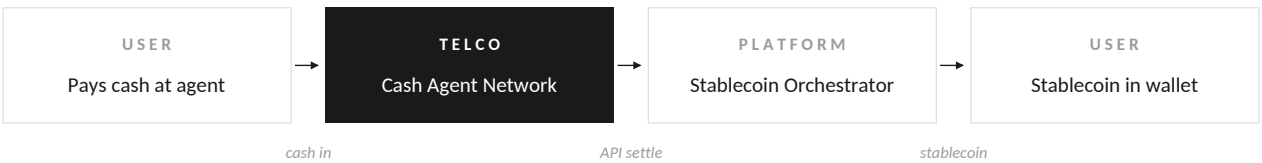
$300 *billion*

A footprint no orchestration platform is going to clone.

AGENT NETWORKS · HUNDREDS OF THOUSANDS OF CASH POINTS EACH

M-PESA	MTN MOMO	ORANGE MONEY	JAZZCASH	EASYPAISA	BKASH
Kenya / Africa	Pan-African	WAEMU + Maghreb	Pakistan	Pakistan	Bangladesh

THE WHOLESALE FLOW



WHO TAKES WHAT

Cash Agent	Per-transaction fee on the cash handling. Telco owns the agent network end-to-end.
Stablecoin Orchestrator	Orchestration fee. Owns the developer relationship with the consumer crypto product.

Telcos are the missing local layer.

Three layers. The middle one is structurally only telcos can build it.

GLOBAL STABLECOIN PLATFORMS

Issuance · Custody · Liquidity · Compliance

Stripe + Bridge · Mastercard + BVNK · Circle · Tether · Coinbase · Fireblocks

↓

TELCO INFRASTRUCTURE — THE MISSING LAYER

Phone-number rails · wholesale agent cash

Six raw assets: identity · billing · mobile money · cash agents · licences · history

↓

LOCAL MARKET ACCESS

Real users in real countries with real cash and real phones

EM populations without cards · diaspora corridors · street-level commerce

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THE STRUCTURAL FACT

The platform layer cannot reach local markets without partners.
The partners it most needs are precisely the telcos that already run them.

Two plug-ins. Two timelines.

Both build on assets the operator already runs. Different prerequisites, different revenue curves.

PLUG-IN #1

Phone number as payment method

Natural starting point for any operator that already runs a successful mobile-money or telco-fintech wallet.

0 – 12 mo

API exposure to consumer crypto surfaces; commercial agreements with on-ramps.

12 – 18 mo

First on-ramp transaction-fee revenue.

18 – 36 mo

Float yield + payment-finance lines stack on top, become the larger part of the line.

PLUG-IN #2

Wholesale cash-in / cash-out

More defensible long-term position. Same commercial model as interconnect, roaming and capacity deals.

0 – 12 mo

Bilateral negotiations with orchestration networks; agent repricing.

12 – 24 mo

Treasury and settlement plumbing live; meaningful B2B revenue.

24+ mo

Structurally durable wholesale line at maturity.

THE HONEST GAME

Sell the assets you already have to a system finally large enough to matter.

LIONSCRAFT



LIONSCRAFT

WEB3 STRATEGY & ADVISORY

If you're thinking about your stablecoin position, we're happy to dig in.

STRATEGY

Stablecoin position, plug-in design, partnership architecture for telcos.

ADVISORY

Commercial structuring with platform layer + orchestration networks.

FOOTPRINT

Operators across EMEA and Asia. Mobile money, identity, agent networks.

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